

The Arbiter's Awakening

Chapter 2: First Descent

Day 4 Since Awakening

Hayami stared at the Hunter job board on their phone, scrolling through listings with increasing desperation. Their bank account showed ¥8,247. Rent was due in ten days. The final paycheck from the convenience store would help, but it wouldn't be enough.

They needed work. Now.

Most of the E-rank listings were garbage—literally. Gate cleanup crews paid ¥3,000 for eight hours of hauling monster corpses and debris. Equipment porter positions paid slightly better at ¥5,000, but required you to carry heavy gear for higher-rank Hunters who treated you like furniture.

Then Hayami saw it:

[D-Rank Gate Raid - Mining Team Member Needed]

- **Gate Location:** Shibuya District, Gate #SB-447
- **Raid Date:** February 11, 2025
- **Duration:** Estimated 6-8 hours
- **Payment:** ¥50,000
- **Requirements:** E-rank or higher, basic mining skills preferred but not required
- **Team Composition:** 1 C-rank leader, 3 D-rank combat, 2 E-rank mining support

Fifty thousand yen. For one day's work. That was more than Hayami had made in two weeks at the convenience store.

The catch? D-rank Gates were significantly more dangerous than E-rank training grounds. Real monsters. Real combat. Real chance of death.

But they'd be mining support. That meant staying in already-cleared areas, harvesting magic stones while the combat team handled any remaining threats. Relatively safe. Probably.

Hayami's finger hovered over the [APPLY] button.

Their daily quest notification blinked in the corner of their vision—they'd completed three days in a row now, and each time felt fractionally less impossible. Their stats had increased by three points each. The Training Manual had taught them to maintain a lightning sphere for twenty-two seconds before it destabilized.

They were still weak. Still E-rank. But maybe not as weak as they'd been four days ago.

They hit [APPLY].

The acceptance notification came within an hour:

[APPLICATION APPROVED] Report to Gate #SB-447 at 06:00 on February 11. Bring your own mining tools (pickaxe, collection bags). Ask for Team Leader Kurosawa.

Hayami screenshot the message and checked the date. February 11. That gave them four days to prepare.

Four days of daily quests. Four more stat increases. Four more reward boxes.

They could do this.

February 11, 2025 - 05:47 AM

The Gate loomed in the middle of a cordoned-off intersection in Shibuya, a vertical tear in reality that pulsed with sickly purple light. It was smaller than Hayami had expected—maybe three meters tall—but the energy radiating from it made their skin prickle. Around the perimeter, Hunter Association guards stood watch, bored and cold in the pre-dawn darkness.

Hayami clutched their borrowed pickaxe (¥2,000 from a hardware store, money they couldn't afford to spend) and approached the checkpoint.

"ID," the guard said without looking up.

Hayami handed over their Hunter license. The guard scanned it, raised an eyebrow at the E-rank designation, then waved them through. "Mining team assembles at the gate entrance. Don't wander off."

Four Hunters stood near the Gate, their equipment marking them as the combat team. The leader was easy to identify—a tall woman in her thirties with a sword strapped to her back and the confident bearing of someone who'd done this hundreds of times. Her license, visible on her chest, showed a silver C.

"You must be the E-rank." Her tone wasn't hostile, just matter-of-fact. "Kurosawa Reina. You know how this works?"

"First time," Hayami admitted.

Kurosawa's expression didn't change, but one of the D-rank Hunters—a muscular man with a hammer nearly as tall as he was—groaned. "Great. A newbie. You know the mortality rate for first-timers?"

"Shut it, Takeshi." Kurosawa turned back to Hayami. "The rules are simple. You stay behind the combat team at all times. You don't engage monsters. You don't touch anything that glows red. When we clear a chamber, you harvest the magic stones from dead monsters and any mineral deposits we mark as safe. You carry a pack with a maximum capacity of 30 kilograms. Anything you harvest beyond your capacity stays in the Gate. Questions?"

"What if something attacks me?"

"Run toward us and try not to die." Kurosawa said it like she was discussing the weather. "We're not responsible for mining team casualties, but we'll do our best to keep you alive. It's bad for our rating if we lose support staff."

Comforting.

The other mining team member arrived—a nervous-looking guy in his twenties who introduced himself as Hiro and immediately started rambling about his three previous mining jobs and how he'd developed a system for optimal stone harvesting and—

Kurosawa cut him off. "We go in five minutes. Last chance to back out."

Hayami's hands were sweating despite the cold. They thought about their apartment. The ¥8,247 in their bank account. The rent due in six days.

"I'm in."

Entering a Gate felt like being swallowed.

One moment, Hayami was standing in a Tokyo intersection with the sunrise just beginning to paint the sky pink. The next, they were in a cave system lit by bioluminescent fungi, the air thick and humid and wrong.

**[NOTICE: You have entered a D-Rank Gate] [Gate Name: Crimson Hollows] [Estimated Difficulty: D]
[Recommended Level: 25-35]**

Level 25? Hayami's status showed Level 4. They pulled up their stats:

[STATS]

- Strength: 16 (+7 from base)
- Agility: 18 (+7)
- Vitality: 15 (+7)
- Intelligence: 20 (+7)
- Sense: 17 (+7)

Seven days of daily quests. Seven stat increases. It felt significant until Hayami looked at the combat team, all of them moving with the casual competence of people whose stats were probably in the fifties or higher.

"Stay close," Hiro whispered, his pickaxe gripped in white-knuckled hands. "And if you see anything move, call it out immediately."

The cave system was a network of tunnels that branched in seemingly random directions. Kurosawa led the team with the confidence of someone who'd memorized the layout, the D-rank combat Hunters flanking her in a practiced formation.

They walked for maybe twenty minutes before they encountered the first monster.

It skittered out of a side tunnel—something between a spider and a crab, the size of a large dog, with too many legs and mandibles that clicked together rhythmically. Its carapace glowed a dull red.

Hayami froze.

The thing looked at them with clusters of eyes that reflected the fungal light. Then it charged.

Takeshi moved before Hayami even processed the threat, his hammer coming down in a devastating arc that crushed the creature mid-leap. It died with a sound like breaking glass, its body dissolving into dark mist. A glowing stone the size of a golf ball clattered to the cave floor.

"Basic Crimson Crawler," Kurosawa said calmly. "This Gate is infested with them. They're not dangerous unless they swarm. Harvest the stone and keep moving."

Hayami's legs felt like water, but they forced themselves forward and picked up the magic stone. It was warm, pulsing with energy. Their System interface flickered:

[Basic Magic Stone acquired] [Value: ¥3,500]

Three and a half thousand yen from one stone. And according to the briefing, a D-rank Gate might contain dozens of monsters.

Maybe this wouldn't be so bad.

Three hours later, Hayami revised that assessment. This was hell.

The combat team had cleared six chambers, each one containing between five and fifteen Crimson Crawlers. Hayami and Hiro scrambled behind them, harvesting stones as fast as their shaking hands could manage. The pack on Hayami's back grew heavier with each addition.

But it was the constant tension that wore them down. Every shadow could hide a monster. Every sound made their heart race. The combat team treated it like a routine job, chatting between fights about restaurant recommendations and whose turn it was to buy drinks after.

Meanwhile, Hayami nearly had a heart attack every time something moved.

"You're doing fine," Hiro said during a brief rest while the combat team scouted ahead. He was sweating profusely, his pickaxe abandoned in favor of just collecting stones. "My first time, I threw up twice and almost ran back to the entrance."

"How do they do it?" Hayami gestured toward the combat team. "Act so calm?"

"Practice. Numbers. When you're Level 30 with stats in the sixties, a bunch of D-rank monsters aren't scary. They're just... work." Hiro wiped his forehead. "That's the thing about being low-rank. Everything is terrifying because everything can actually kill you."

A scream echoed from deeper in the tunnels.

The combat team reacted instantly, weapons drawn, formation tight. Kurosawa held up a fist—the signal to wait. Another scream, cut short.

"There's another team in here," Takeshi said, his expression grim. "That's not a combat sound. That's a death sound."

Kurosawa made the decision immediately. "We move forward. Combat formation. Mining team, stay in the center."

They found the other team in a large chamber filled with the remains of at least twenty Crawlers. Three bodies—no, two bodies and one person still alive, barely. A young woman, maybe Hayami's age, with her leg crushed beneath a collapsed pile of rocks. Her Hunter license showed E-rank.

"Trap chamber," Kurosawa assessed quickly. "They triggered the ceiling collapse. Tanaka, stabilize her. Takeshi, check for survivors."

The other two combat team members moved to help, but Hayami could see it in Kurosawa's face—they weren't fast enough. The woman was losing too much blood. Her breathing was shallow, rattling.

"Please," the woman gasped. "Please, I don't want to—"

She didn't finish. Her eyes went blank.

[A Hunter has died]

The System notification appeared cold and clinical in Hayami's vision. They stared at it, then at the body, then at their own shaking hands.

That could have been them. One wrong step. One monster they didn't see coming. One trap they didn't know to avoid.

"Collect their licenses," Kurosawa ordered, her voice flat. "We'll report it when we exit. There's nothing else we can do."

Hiro looked like he was going to be sick. Hayami felt numb.

They kept going.

By the time the combat team declared the Gate cleared, Hayami's pack weighed exactly 29.8 kilograms—they'd checked obsessively, terrified of going over the limit and having to discard stones. Their entire body ached. Their mind kept replaying the moment that woman died.

Emerging from the Gate felt like being born again—sudden, disorienting, almost painful. The Tokyo morning was bright and normal and utterly surreal after hours in that nightmare cave.

Kurosawa handled the reporting of the casualties with practiced efficiency while the combat team divided up the monster loot. Hayami and Hiro were directed to the Hunter Association's on-site buying station.

The attendant weighed Hayami's haul without comment: forty-seven basic magic stones, three refined stones from a larger Crawler variant, and a chunk of crimson ore that had taken ten minutes of pickaxe work to extract.

"Total value: ¥185,000. Your contracted payment is ¥50,000. The remaining ¥135,000 goes to the raid team leader for distribution. Sign here."

Hayami signed. Their hands were still shaking.

The ¥50,000 hit their account instantly. For eight hours of the most terrifying experience of their life, they'd earned enough to cover rent with money left over.

"Hey." Hiro caught up to them as they were leaving. "You did good for a first-timer. Didn't panic, didn't slow us down. That's rare."

"Someone died."

"Yeah." Hiro's expression darkened. "That happens. Not often with experienced teams, but it happens. Those three... they were a self-formed E-rank party. No raid leader, no support, just three friends trying to make some money." He shook his head. "The Association shouldn't have let them register for a D-rank Gate."

But they had. Because Hunters died all the time, and the Association needed bodies to clear Gates, and E-ranks were expendable.

Hayami walked to the station in a daze, their phone notifying them of the payment over and over as if it couldn't quite believe it either.

The convenience store looked smaller than Hayami remembered. They pushed through the door, and the manager looked up from the register with an expression that cycled through surprise, awkwardness, and resignation.

"Amamiya. I wasn't sure you'd come."

"Here for my final paycheck."

The manager printed out the slip and handed it over with an envelope. "¥43,780. I included your overtime from last month."

Hayami took it without counting. "Thanks."

"How's... how's the Hunter work going?"

"Fine." The lie came easily. "It's fine."

They left before the manager could ask more questions, the envelope feeling insignificant compared to the Gate payment. In one day of Hell, they'd earned more than two weeks at the store. The math was simple, brutal, efficient.

This was their life now.

Back at their apartment, Hayami collapsed onto their bed and stared at the ceiling. The daily quest notification blinked patiently:

[DAILY QUEST: FOUNDATION TRAINING]

One hundred push-ups. One hundred sit-ups. One hundred squats. Ten kilometers.

Their body screamed at the thought. Every muscle was already exhausted from eight hours of crouching, harvesting, hauling. Their mind kept showing them that woman's blank eyes.

But the penalty for failure was -2 to all stats. And those stats were the only thing standing between them and becoming another casualty statistic.

Hayami dragged themselves off the bed and got into push-up position.

As they worked through the quest, something nagged at them. A realization that had been forming all day.

In the Gate, they'd watched the combat team. Watched how they moved, how they fought, how they coordinated. All of them were skilled, experienced, powerful.

But none of them had mentioned daily quests. No one talked about stat increases or reward boxes or training manuals. When Hiro had given advice, it was all practical stuff—which stones were most valuable, how to spot unstable tunnels, where to position yourself for fastest harvesting.

Nothing about the System pushing them to train. Nothing about quests at all.

(47/100)

What if the daily quests weren't standard? What if the System only gave them to certain people?

Or worse—what if Hayami was the only one getting them?

(73/100)

Kurosawa was Level 38, according to her publicly visible stats. The D-rank combat team ranged from Level 28 to 32. All of them strong, experienced, capable.

But if they'd been getting daily quests since their Awakening, wouldn't they be higher level? Wouldn't everyone be?

(100/100) ✓

Hayami moved on to sit-ups, their mind racing faster than their aching body.

The Training Manual had appeared from a Random Reward Box. None of the other Hunters had mentioned anything like that. When they talked about skill development, it was all about practice, repetition, expensive skill books purchased from the Hunter Association.

No one mentioned the System just... giving them training materials.

(100/100) ✓

The squats were agony, but Hayami pushed through, the pieces clicking together.

The System had called their Awakening "unauthorized." The Association had been notified immediately, like it was an exception rather than a rule. Everyone said your rank was fixed at Awakening, that the System's assessment was absolute.

But Hayami's stats had increased by seven points in a week. Their lightning control had improved dramatically. The Training Manual had taught them techniques that felt almost instinctual now.

(100/100) ✓

They grabbed their phone and headed out for the run, their legs protesting every step. The night air was cold and sharp, cutting through their exhaustion.

Ten kilometers. Same as every night.

As they ran, Hayami thought about all the Hunters they'd seen today. Confident. Powerful. Treating the Gate like a job because that's what it was to them.

None of them looked like they were training obsessively every single day. None of them had the desperate, hungry energy of someone trying to claw their way up from the bottom.

(4.2/10 km)

Because they didn't need to. They'd Awakened at C-rank or D-rank, already strong enough to make a living. Already powerful enough to survive.

The System gave them status windows and basic functionality, but not... this. Not the relentless push to improve. Not the daily grind. Not the rewards for persistence.

(7.8/10 km)

Hayami's legs moved mechanically, their breath coming in steady rhythms they'd learned over seven days of forced training. Their mind was sharp despite the exhaustion, the increased Intelligence stat making connections they wouldn't have seen before.

They were special. Not in a good way—they were still E-rank, still weak, still barely scraping by. But their System was different. More demanding. More... potential?

(10.0/10 km) ✓

[DAILY QUEST COMPLETE!]

[+1 to all stats]

[Random Reward Box obtained!]

Hayami stopped running and bent over, hands on knees, gasping. Around them, Tokyo glittered with lights and life and normalcy. Somewhere, high-rank Hunters were probably at fancy parties or expensive restaurants, living the celebrity lifestyle.

And here was Hayami, E-rank nobody, completing their eighth daily quest in a row, slowly building stats one point at a time.

If they were right—if the System was unique to them—then everything changed. The Association had assessed them as E-rank with no potential. Had basically written them off as another low-level Hunter who'd spend their life doing menial Gate work or dying in some tunnel somewhere.

But the System didn't agree. The System kept pushing them. Training them. Rewarding them.

The question was: why?

Hayami opened the Random Reward Box:

[Item Acquired: Basic Mana Recovery Potion (x3)]

Three small vials materialized in their hands, glowing with soft blue light. The description read:

Restores 100 mana instantly. Cannot be used in combat.

Mana potions were expensive—about ¥15,000 for a basic one at the Association store. The System had just given them ¥45,000 worth of supplies for free.

Hayami stared at the potions for a long moment, then carefully stored them in their inventory—another System feature that apparently wasn't standard, based on how everyone at the Gate had carried physical packs.

Tomorrow, they'd complete the daily quest again. And the day after. And the day after that.

Because either the System was wrong, and they were wasting their time grinding for nothing.

Or everyone else was wrong, and E-rank was just their starting point.

Hayami walked home slowly, their body exhausted but their mind alive with possibilities.

Eight days since Awakening. Level 4. Still weak. Still broke. Still alive.

That was enough for now.

[END OF CHAPTER 2]